

# DUNIGAN FOLK

Department of Psychology  
University of Pennsylvania  
dunigan@sas.upenn.edu

## EDUCATION & ACADEMIC TRAINING

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### **MindCORE Postdoctoral Fellow**

University of Pennsylvania

Sept. 2025 – Present

*Advisors:* Dr. Angela Duckworth & Dr. Lyle Ungar

### **Ph.D. in Psychology, Social Psychology**

University of British Columbia, Vancouver, Canada

Sept. 2021 – Aug. 2025

*Advisors:* Dr. Elizabeth Dunn & Dr. Steven Heine

### **M.A. in Psychology, Social Psychology**

University of British Columbia, Vancouver, Canada

Sept. 2019 – Aug. 2021

*Advisors:* Dr. Elizabeth Dunn & Dr. Steven Heine

### **B.Sc. Psychology (Hons.)**

University of British Columbia Okanagan (UBCO)

Sept. 2016 – May 2019

*Advisor:* Dr. Marvin Krank

Cumulative GPA: 90.3%

University of Regina

Sept. 2014 – May 2016

## GRANTS

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Gates Foundation, “Gallup study of Gen Z and parents on using AI and impact on well-being,” March 20<sup>th</sup>, 2026 to June 30<sup>th</sup>, 2026 (\$186,000)

- Co-Principal Investigator

## FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

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### **Psychology of Technology Institute Dissertation Award**

Psychology of Technology Institute | \$1,500

2026

### **SSHRC Postdoctoral Fellowship** (offered, declined)

Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada | \$140,000

2025

### **Psychology Department Fellowship**

University of British Columbia | \$18,000

2024

### **Psychology Department Fellowship**

University of British Columbia | \$7,784

2024

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| <b>Social and Personality Psychology Department Leadership Award</b><br>University of British Columbia<br><i>Awarded to one student per year in recognition of their service and participation in the department.</i> | 2023      |
| <b>Stanley Coren Award for Most Outstanding Master's Thesis</b><br>University of British Columbia   \$250                                                                                                             | 2022      |
| <b>Joseph-Armand Bombardier Canada Graduate Scholarship - Doctoral</b><br>Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada   \$105,000                                                                       | 2021-2024 |
| <b>Graduate Entrance Scholarship</b><br>University of British Columbia   \$17,500                                                                                                                                     | 2020-2021 |
| <b>Department of Psychology Award</b><br>University of British Columbia   \$5,096                                                                                                                                     | 2020-2021 |
| <b>Canada Graduate Scholarship – Master's (CGS-M)</b><br>Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada   \$17,500                                                                                         | 2019-2020 |

#### PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

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- Folk, D. & Dunn, E. (2026).** How does turning to AI for companionship predict loneliness and vice versa? *Psychological Science*, 37(4), 276-286.  
<https://doi.org/10.1177/09567976261427747>
- Folk, D., Henninger, M., & Dunn, E. (2026).** What does a good day look like?: An interpretable machine learning approach to the American Time Use Survey. *PNAS Nexus*, 5(3). <https://doi.org/10.1093/pnasnexus/pgag014>
- Folk, D., & Dunn E. (2026).** Everything is better together: Analyzing the relationship between socializing and happiness in the American Time Use Survey. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, 17(4), 426-435.  
<https://doi.org/10.1177/19485506251364333>
- Maheshka, C., Folk, D., & Dunn, E. (2026).** Harnessing artificial intelligence to facilitate difficult conversations. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*.  
<https://doi.org/10.1177/19485506261444068>
- Li, R.-N., Folk, D., Singh, A., Ungar, L., & Dunn, E. (2026).** Is a random human peer better than a highly supportive chatbot in reducing loneliness over time? *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 125, 104911  
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jesp.2026.104911>

- Folk, D.,** Wu, C., & Heine, S. (2025). Cultural variation in attitudes towards social chatbots. *Journal of Cross-Cultural Psychology*, 56(3). <https://doi.org/10.1177/00220221251317950>
- Folk, D.,** Heine, S., & Dunn, E. (2025). Individual differences in anthropomorphism help explain social connection to AI companions. *Scientific Reports*, 15(1), 36548. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-19212-2>
- Jettinghoff, W., **Folk, D.,** Radjaee, P., Willard, A., Norenzayan, A., & Heine, S. J. (2025). The varieties of nonreligious experience: meaning in life among believers, non-believers, and the spiritual but not religious. *Religion, Brain & Behavior*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/2153599X.2025.2546324>
- Mask, M., **Folk, D.,** & Heine, S. (2025). How sources of purpose predict meaning in life, happiness, and psychological richness across cultures. *Journal of Positive Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2025.2500562>
- Folk, D.,** Dunn, E. (2024). Reply to: Strength of evidence for five happiness strategies. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 8(9). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-024-01955-z>
- Folk, D.,** Yu, S.J., & Dunn, E. (2024). Can chatbots ever provide more social connection than humans? *Collabra: Psychology*, 10(1). <https://doi.org/10.1525/collabra.117083>
- Folk, D.,** & Savalei, V. (2024). Examining the performance of the chi-square difference test when the unrestricted model is slightly misspecified. *Behavior Research Methods*, 56(7). <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13428-024-02384-6>
- Folk, D.,** Rutjens, B. T., Van Elk, M., & Heine, S. (2024). Dare to know! The existential costs of a faith in science. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 20(1). <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2024.2314294>
- Folk, D.,** & Dunn, E. (2024). How can people become happier? A systematic review of preregistered experiments. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 75. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-022423-030818>
- Folk, D.,** & Dunn, E. (2023). A systematic review of the strength of evidence for the most commonly recommended happiness strategies in mainstream media. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 7(10). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-023-01651-4>
- Featured on the October 2023 cover of *Nature Human Behavior*
- Okabe-Miyamoto, K., **Folk, D.,** Lyubomirsky, S., & Dunn, E. (2021). Changes in social connection during COVID-19 social distancing: It's not (household) size that matters, it's who you're with. *PloS one*. 16(1). <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0245009>

Lutz, P. K., O'Connor, B. P., & **Folk, D.** (2021). Dimensionality, item response theory, effect size attenuation, and test bias analyses of the self-importance of moral identity scale (SIMIS). *Journal of Personality Assessment*.  
<https://doi.org/10.1080/00223891.2021.1991359>

**Folk, D.**, Okabe-Miyamoto, K., Dunn, E., & Lyubomirsky, S. (2020). Did social connection decline during the first wave of COVID-19?: The role of extraversion. *Collabra: Psychology*, 6(1). <https://doi.org/10.1525/collabra.365>

#### CHAPTERS IN EDITED VOLUMES

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Heine, S. J., **Folk, D.**, Guan, K. W., Benjamin, R., Bahng, J. M., & Proulx, T. (2024). An ecology of meaning: An integrative framework for understanding human motivations. *Advances in Motivation Science*, 11.

#### MANUSCRIPTS UNDER CONSIDERATION

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**Folk, D.**, Cai, J., Stenlund, S., Dunn, E. A within-person experiment testing the mood benefits of brief gratitude, meditation, and nature interventions. *Revise and Resubmit at Communications Psychology*

**Folk, D.**, Ungar, L., Duckworth, A. Using AI for companionship is most common among women and less wealthy Americans. *Under Review*

#### PRESENTATIONS AND POSTERS

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**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2026, May 6<sup>th</sup>). Can AI companions reduce loneliness? *Invited talk at Stanford CREATE Webinar Series*.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2026, April 26<sup>th</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection? *Invited talk at Yale Social Psychology Current Works Talk Series*.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. & Dunn, E. (2026, February 26<sup>th</sup>-28<sup>th</sup>). Everything is Better Together. Happiness Preconference, Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Chicago, IL, United States

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2025, November 18<sup>th</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection and happiness? *Invited talk at the University of Toronto*.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2025, October 24<sup>th</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection and happiness? *Invited talk at the MindCORE Seminar Series at the University of Pennsylvania*.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2025, October 22<sup>nd</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection and happiness? *Invited talk at the Social Psychology Seminar Series at the University of Pennsylvania*.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2025, March 27<sup>th</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection and happiness? *Invited talk at the University of Pennsylvania.*

**Presentation.** Folk, D. & Dunn, E. (2025, February 20th-22nd). Turning to AI for companionship predicts decreased social connection 4 months later. Psychology of Media and Technology Preconference, Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Denver, CO, United States.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. & Dunn, E. (2025, February 20th-22nd). Anthropomorphism promotes social connection with conversational AI. Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Denver, CO, United States.

**Poster.** “What makes a good day?: A random forest analysis of the American Time Use Survey”. Happiness Preconference, Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Denver, CO, United States, February 20<sup>th</sup>, 2025.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2024, October 28<sup>th</sup>). How does AI companionship shape social connection and happiness? *Invited talk at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology.*

**Presentation.** Folk, D., Wu, C., & Heine, S. (2024, February 8th-10th). Cultural variation in attitudes towards social chatbots. Society for Personality and Social Psychology, San Diego, CA, United States.

**Presentation.** Folk, D. (2023). When, why, and for whom do chatbots provide feelings of social connection? *Invited talk at University of British Columbia, Okanagan*

**Poster.** “Do people turn to chatbots as a source of social connection in their lives?” Psychology of Technology and Media Preconference, Society for Personality and Social Psychology, Atlanta, GA, United States, February 8<sup>th</sup>, 2023.

**Presentation.** Folk, D., Yu, S., & Dunn, E. (2022, February 16th-19th). Is a good bot better than a mediocre human?: Chatbots as alternative sources of social connection. Society for Personality and Social Psychology, San Francisco, CA, United States.

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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**Teaching Assistant, Technology and the Good Life**  
University of Pennsylvania

Sept. 2025-Dec. 2025

**Teaching Assistant, Measurement in Psychology**  
**(Graduate-level course)**  
University of British Columbia

Sept. 2024-Dec. 2024

**Teaching Assistant, Existential Psychology**

Jan. 2023-Apr. 2023

University of British Columbia

**Teaching Assistant, Cultural Psychology**  
University of British Columbia

Jan. 2022-Apr. 2022

**Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Psychology**  
University of British Columbia

Jan. 2021-Apr. 2021

**Teaching Assistant, Science of Happiness**  
University of British Columbia

Sept. 2019-Dec. 2019

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**DEPARTMENTAL SERVICE**

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**President Of Graduate Student Society, Psychology**  
University of British Columbia

Sept. 2022 -Aug. 2023

**Diversity Mentor**  
University of British Columbia

May 2021 – January 2025

*Mentored undergraduate students from under-represented groups as they navigated graduate school applications.*